

High Standards

Pekka Väyrynen :: University of Leeds

1. Introduction

The standards of morality and rationality may be very demanding. But I don't think they require perfection. Not so, say recent linguistic arguments: only what's perfectly morally good is morally good (Mankowitz 2024) and only what's optimally rational is rational (Siscoe 2021; 2023).

I'll argue that 'rational' and moral 'good' have non-maximal but typically demanding standards. Part of my argument draws on special features of normative and evaluative discourse. Part of it challenges standard classifications of gradable adjectives in linguistics.

2. Gradable Adjectives

Moral 'good' and 'rational' are gradable adjectives (GA). Prevailing view in linguistics: GAs denote a *function* from *individuals* to *degrees on scales*.

Linguists divide GAs into *relative* and (maximal and minimal) *absolute* adjectives. These vary in both *scale structure* and *standard type*.

- Prevailing view: a very strong correlation between *open scales* and *relative standards* and *closed scales* and *absolute standards*.
- E.g. 'tall' is associated with an *open scale* and this favors a standard that varies *relative* to context. ('RA' for short.)
- E.g. 'full' is associated with an *upper-closed scale* and this seems to favor a *maximum-degree absolute standard*. ('MxA' for short.)
- Of particular interest here: the "Maximalist Correlation".

Whether an *evaluative* adjective is relative or absolute matters a great deal.

- A lot of normative inquiry supposes that normative standards don't vary by context as freely as with 'tall', 'old', or 'cheap'.
- Wes Siscoe: 'rational' (applied to actions/beliefs) is MxA; "being rational requires being at the top of the scale of rationality, making

anyone who is not fully rational positively irrational".

- Poppy Mankowitz: 'good' is ambiguous between moral 'good' and non-moral 'good'; the latter is RA, the former MxA. Thus "agents and acts can only count as strictly morally 'good' if they have the maximum degree of moral goodness".
- Call this semantics 'Maximalism'. It rules out e.g. supererogation in cases where the worse but permissible option is also good.

These arguments are based on various general tests for GAs but the results conflict with widely shared intuitions about value and rationality.

- There's significant theoretical pressure not to treat evaluative adjectives as formally exceptional.
- But general tests devised by reference to more tractable prototypical cases may not be reliable in all cases.

3. The Degree Modification Test

MxAs combine—but RAs don't—with two types of degree modifier. *Maximizers* indicate that an endpoint has been reached:

- (1) a. The stick is (perfectly / completely / totally / 100%) straight.
b. The fox is (#perfectly / #completely / #totally / #100%) large.

'Rational' and moral 'good' admit maximizers—evidence of closed scale:

- (2) a. The husband did not do what was (perfectly / completely / ideally) rational. (Cf. Siscoe 2023: 117.)
b. Mary is completely rational in her belief. (Siscoe 2021: 73.)
c. It was (perfectly / fully / completely) rational to take the train.
d. No humans are (completely / totally / absolutely / fully / perfectly) good. (Mankowitz 2024: 660.)
e. Your hastiness to put women into the totally good or evil sociopath categories is shortsighted.
f. I'm helping you out, but... I'm not a completely good guy.
g. In the "Imagined" environment man can be perfectly good and

happy when he isn't influenced by the boundaries which cause competition, strife, and war.¹

If there's a strong tendency for upper-closed GAs to have maximal standards, this test is evidence that 'rational' and moral 'good' are MxAs.

Approximators indicate proximity to a maximum point:

- (3) a. The stick is (almost / nearly) straight.
- b. The fox is (#almost / #nearly) large.

'Rational' and moral 'good' combine much less well with approximators:

- (4) a. Mary is (?almost / ?nearly) rational in her belief.
- b. What she's doing for others is (?almost / ?nearly) good.

So the degree modification test delivers mixed results. (I think 'rational' and moral 'good' also don't match neatly with what the question felicity test and the 'point to' test tell us about absolute and relative adjectives.)

4. Infinite Value and Scale Structure

Q: To what extent do the conventions of the language determine the structure of the scale associated with 'rational' and moral 'good'? A: Even if many contexts associate them with upper-closed scales, not all do.

- Lassiter: "There is no conceptual limitation on how good (or bad) a proposition could be" (2017: 177). (He argues 'good' is RA.)

RAs can combine felicitously with 'infinitely' and so can 'good':

- (7) a. God is infinitely [big / old / good / ?rational / #dead / #pure].

Maybe it's not clear what 'infinitely good/rational' might mean. But if talk of infinite value and utility is coherent, the associated scale doesn't have an endpoint and so the standard in those uses cannot be maximal. If such talk can be felicitous, an adequate semantics should be able to explain that.

¹ Mankowitz reports (2e-g) from The Corpus of Contemporary American English.

My argument so far allows that 'rational' and moral 'good' are associated with upper-closed scales in many contexts. (Could be because they're polysemous or because they're associated with contextual functions that may differ with respect to scale structure. Lots of issues here!) Standard classification of GAs implies that this favors a maximum-degree standard *in those contexts*. I think even this is wrong, on at least three grounds.

One argument is quick: the standard argument for why upper-closed scales strongly favor maximal interpretations appeals to Kennedy's (2007) *principle of interpretive economy*. But even if plausible, IE cannot do this work in cases where scale structure isn't conventionally determined.

5. Multidimensionality

Maximalism cannot account for multidimensional uses of 'rational' and moral 'good' under plausible assumptions about dimensional aggregation. (Siscoe assumes 'rational' has a unidimensional scale of expected utility.)

A multidimensional adjective '*F*' is associated with a set of underlying dimensions of *F*_{ness} (dimensional specification), orderings on which must somehow be aggregated into a scale to yield verdicts about overall *F*_{ness} (dimensional aggregation). E.g. 'healthy', 'intelligent'.

Moral 'good' and 'rational' pass the standard test for MD (Sassoon 2013). They admit quantificational and respect-denoting propositional phrases:

- (8) a. He's a good person, except for his (impatience / coldness).
- b. In what (way / respects) is progressive taxation good?
- c. The outcome was good except with respect to inequality.
- d. It was a rational solution except for his procrastination.
- e. His beliefs are rational with respect to how coherent they are but not w.r.t. to how well-proportioned they are to the evidence.
- f. Except for your mixed motives, you did (otherwise / all in all) a good thing.
- g. Your route choice was (mostly / largely / relatively) rational, except for the predictable rush hour traffic on that stretch of A65.

But MDAs will often fail to receive a maximal interpretation.

- There will often be multiple admissible aggregation functions for a multidimensional adjective ‘*F*’ (D’Ambrosio and Hedden 2024).
- Different aggregation functions induce different orderings.
- If *a* is *F* or *a* is more *F* than *b* on one admissible aggregation function but not all, then ‘*a* is *F*’ and ‘*a* is more *F* than *b*’ aren’t determinately true or determinately false.
- This vagueness/indeterminacy precludes a maximal interpretation even if the scale is upper-closed. The degree that closes the scale of *F*_{ness} provides a sharp cut-off, not a borderline case of ‘*F*’.

Multiple aggregation functions seem admissible for many multidimensional uses of ‘rational’ and moral ‘good’.

6. Supererogation

Maximalism cannot adequately explain felicitous claims of rational and moral supererogation. (Siscoe describes rational supererogation as “the thought that someone can do what’s rational while failing to do what is most rational”.) There are compelling examples of both kinds. Often a morally good thing has better but non-obligatory alternatives. Or consider:

The Mathematician: Omari, who enjoys a full and balanced life, wants to be the best mathematician in his school. One day, his school is closed because of snow. His parents tell him he may make a snowman in the garden. Although tempted, Omari instead spends two hours revising maths, bringing him closer to realising his mathematical goal.

The benefits of extra revision outweigh the costs, so revising is rationally optimal. Yet, common sense suggests that it would also be rationally permissible for Omari to give revision a miss. (Benn & Bales 2019.)

The standard maximalist response: many ordinary uses of absolute GAs are *imprecise* i.e.: strictly false but may be felicitous e.g. by implicating the truth that a non-maximally full jar is full enough for current purposes.

The explanation requires mid-sentence context shifts à la (9a):

- (9) a. The stick is straight, but it isn’t completely straight.
b. What she’s doing is good but it could be better. (Here’s how.)
- (10) a. Both options A and B are good but A is significantly better.
b. Both options A and B are rational but A is notably more so.

I find this wanting. In (10b) the ellipsis rules out a context shift. Embedding (10a) under a belief operator may do so as well (Siu 2021). A further issue: if (9)-(10) were loose talk, we might expect the order of conjuncts to matter (Carter 2021: 174-75; but see also Dinges 2024):

- (11) a. The stick is straight, but it isn’t completely straight.
b. ?? The stick isn’t completely straight, but it’s straight.

I find nothing like such sensitivity in moral ‘good’ and ‘rational’:

- (12) a. Taking a week off because of burnout is rational, but it isn’t completely rational (it’s more rational to take a week off to prevent burnout).
b. Taking a week off because of burnout isn’t completely rational (it’s more rational to take a week off to prevent burnout) but it is rational.
- (13) a. Doing the right thing through strength of will is good, but it’s not completely good (it’s better not to be tempted at all).
b. Doing the right thing through strength of will isn’t completely good (better not to be tempted at all) but it is good.

There’s also a conceptual problem:

- A supererogatory act must be sufficiently good to be commendable or praiseworthy; its merely permissible alternative often isn’t.
- But if imprecisely describing one option as ‘good’ conveys that it’s sufficiently morally good for current purposes, then imprecisely describing the other as ‘good’ should do the same.

And there's a significant theoretical cost: Mid-sentence context shifts are difficult and special, so positing them all around should be a large burden.

So I don't see that expressions of rational and moral supererogation can be adequately explained as imprecise uses of 'rational' and moral 'good'.

Out of curiosity: how does (14) sound? (Doesn't sound bad to me.)

(14) Option A is strictly speaking good, and option B is even better.

7. Keeping High Standards

My proposal: 'rational' and moral 'good' (i) typically have semantically non-maximal standards irrespective of whether the associated scale is upper-closed; (ii) these standards are typically fairly demanding.

- Relativist version: 'rational' and moral 'good' are associated with standards that may vary contextually but only within certain principled constraints that force demanding standards.
- Absolutist version: they're associated with context-invariant demanding standards.
- Deciding between these is far from trivial. On each view, 'rational' and moral 'good' are a special kind of gradable adjectives.
- But this is fine given the problems with the standard classification.

So far I've defended (i). Claim (ii) isn't special pleading. Evaluative adjectives are characteristically used to commend, approve, praise, etc.

- In such uses, describing something as 'rational' or morally 'good' tends to be informative only insofar as the standard is sufficiently demanding to support commendation or praise.
- Limit cases: when we call 'good' things that are just satisfactory for the present purposes. But it's a good question how often/easily this occurs in *moral* discourse.
- This normative aspect of use doesn't require a suitably demanding degree to be at the extreme end of the scale, but also doesn't permit it to travel as freely on scale as we see in 'tall' and 'cheap'.

- We routinely commend (and certainly permit) actions that are not perfectly morally good, nor completely rational.
- Perhaps evaluative adjectives play this commendatory role in virtue of their meanings.
- Or perhaps it's a general discourse assumption (reflecting a typical point of evaluation) that speakers use 'rational' and moral 'good' in a commendatory way.
- Either way, association with demanding standards is predictable given certain special features of moral and rationality discourse.
- Whether a *normatively demanding* degree of an evaluative property corresponds to a high *semantic* degree depends on further issues of scale structure and their metaphysical implications.

[If there's time: my proposal can also explain the putative data from the question felicity test and the 'point to' or selection test. Re the latter:

- Typical RAs can be used to distinguish objects in the middle of the scale; MxAs don't permit this use.
- Association with demanding standards may be enough to explain why you can't take two middling acts on the scale of moral goodness or rationality and felicitously say 'Select the (good / rational) one'.]